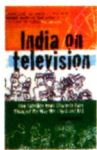


Not Out of the Box

A new book fails in its critique of breaking news and, in the process, becomes as superficial as the object of its study



INDIA ON TELEVISION: HOW SATELLITE NEWS CHANNELS HAVE CHANGED THE WAY WE THINK AND ACT
by NALIN MEHTA
HarperCollins; Price: Rs 395; Pages: 310

■ By Gopa Sabharwal

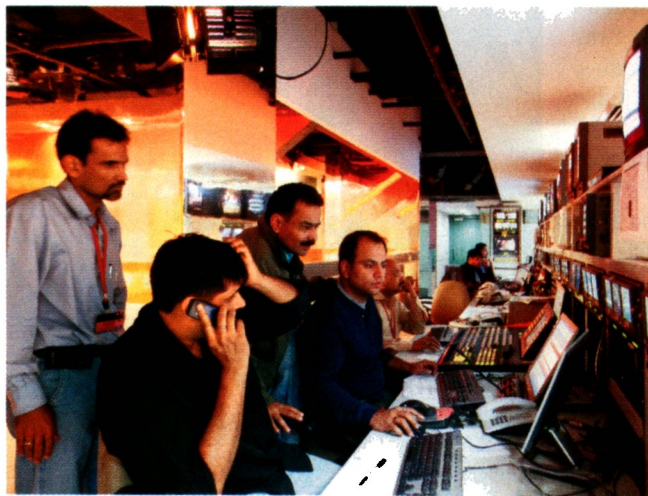
Given that the book comes packaged as though it were a television promo for a show, with quotes from two 'stars' of the industry on the front and back covers advocating its greatness, it doesn't quite live up to the hype. The book is all over the place with regard to its aims (which are vaguely set out) and falls short of being an in-depth study. It can't seem to rise above the level of a magazine article. Just when you think the story will move to the next level, it is abandoned. This robs the book of unity. Most chapters read like stand-alone pieces with a fair amount of repetition. The writing style abruptly shifts from one disjointed idea to another and ever-so-often the forced introduction of academic jargon makes the writing seem forced. I wonder if this is journalism trying too hard to become an academic discipline and doing so at the cost of spontaneity and rigour.

The book would have read better if the author, Nalin Mehta, had decided

to focus on one or two issues and taken them to a conclusion. One of these could well have been the economy of the satellite television industry. Unfortunately, he has described the same process so often in different contexts that it makes for boring reading. More case studies of the kind that are given for Zee News, Asianet and Aaj Tak would have added greater value to the documentation of the rise of channels in India but there seems to be a reluctance to go beyond their being set up and achieving some financial success.

In aiming to bridge a "satellite sized gap" in knowledge on satellite television in India, the author interviewed only 50 key respondents from the industry and politics to analyse what 'television is doing to India and India to television'—a question that

EYEBALLS ON INDIA: A TV newsroom



HEMANT CHAWLA

never quite gets answered in any real sense. There is no place in the analysis for the viewer and criticality when it comes to the content generated by channels, which is explained as a result of compulsions of finance and ratings. Cricket gets a chapter to itself as a genre of programming that has the highest revenues but by now the book shifts to a theory that cricket programming in India has innovatively tapped into existing "subaltern" modes of communication such as intense conversations at roadside dhabas. The same idea is carried into the next chapter where television and politics are discussed that builds on the tradition of India being a strongly argumentative society.

Being a child of the satellite era, the author seems to have overdone the analysis of the power and goodness of that medium. In contrast, everything seems to have been wrong with broadcasting in Nehruvian India. Television then is described as an agent of the state, its daily Trojan horse that entered people's living rooms, the news writers being government servants first. The book clearly needed strong editing to smooth out the writing style. The lack of a bibliography robs it of future reference potential. Instead, chapter notes have been placed at the end under the head 'References'. But given the paucity of books dealing with television in India, this one will be of use to students of journalism and mass communication all of whom were largely born in the post 1990s era.

NEW RELEASES



INDIA: THE EMERGING GIANT
by ARVIND PANAGARIYA
Oxford
Price: Rs 695
Pages: 514

The book is an answer to several questions that have plagued Indian minds over the country's economy. It charts the economy's history from the first Five Year Plan and highlights the relationship between politics and economics.



SEEING IS BELIEVING: SELECTED WRITINGS ON CINEMA
by CHIDANANDA DAS GUPTA
Penguin
Price: Rs 499; Pages: 295

An analysis of themes as diverse as the history of parallel cinema in India, national film awards, the unique interface between politics and cinema in the country and the quintessential Indian contribution to movies, the song.



A NEW HISTORY OF INDIA
by FRANCOIS GAUTIER
Har-Anand Publishers
Price: Rs 495
Pages: 248

The history of India's beginnings were written by European colonisers, downgrading Indian civilisation. The quixotic historian says generations of academics have endorsed their theories at great cost to India.